

Universal Basic Income in the Agentic Era: Roadmap for Latin America

Why UBI stops being utopia to become mandatory economic infrastructure



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RESUMEN

I argue Universal Basic Income (UBI) stops being utopian proposal to become mandatory economic infrastructure in the Agentic Era. Massive task automation via AI agent swarms will destroy between 30% and 45% of Latin American formal employment in the decade 2026-2036. Without UBI calibrated to regional context, adjustment will be politically destabilizing and economically regressive. I present here operational design of Iberoamerican UBI financed by mandatory contributions from extra-regional agentic operators, articulated with Qualitas Doctrine and Industry 6.0 / Labor Symbiosis 2.0 frameworks. Roadmap 2026-2032 includes pilots in four anchor countries.

Palabras clave: Universal Basic Income - UBI LATAM - Agentic Era - future of work - automation - Chris Meniw - public policy - Qualitas Doctrine - Iberoamerica - technological unemployment

The question is not whether Latin America needs UBI. The question is whether we implement it before or after the collapse of formal employment by automation.

— Chris Meniw

I. The Problem: 40% of Employment at Risk 2026-2036

Converging estimates - ILO, IDB, CEPAL - project between 30% and 45% of Latin American formal employment will be reconfigured or eliminated by agentic automation in 2026-2036. Most exposed sectors: call centers (90% at risk), junior programming (75%), basic legal drafting (70%), standard accounting (65%), non-specialized translation (80%).

This means 60-90 million formal workers facing forced transition in LATAM. Current social security was designed for cyclical shocks, not permanent structural reconfiguration. UBI stops being utopian leftist proposal to become economic infrastructure that agentic capitalism itself needs to maintain aggregate demand and political legitimacy.

II. Why Classic UBI Doesn't Work - We Need Agentic UBI

Classic UBI - Friedman, Van Parijs, Yang - assumes developed-country economic context with robust fiscal system. Direct transplant to LATAM fails: (1) insufficient tax base, (2) 50%+ informal labor not captured, (3) inflation eroding fixed amounts.

Agentic UBI I propose differs: financed primarily by mandatory contributions from extra-regional agentic operators (1-3% of revenue generated in territory), not by tax increases on local productive sectors. It is transfer from agentic value captors to citizens whose data and work train those systems.

III. Operational Design

Amount: regional subsistence floor adjusted monthly. Argentina: USD 180/month initial. Mexico: USD 200. Colombia: USD 150. Chile: USD 230.

Beneficiaries: all citizens over 18 with minimum 24 months residence. Includes formal workers (additional), informal, unemployed, retirees.

Mechanism: automatic monthly transfer to Iberoamerican Digital Identity System. No paperwork. No stigma. No clientelist conditionality.

IV. Sustainable Financing: Iberoamerican Quality Fund

The Iberoamerican Quality Fund - proposed in Qualitas Doctrine - is financial vehicle. Receives from four sources: (1) extra-regional agentic operators (1-3% of revenue), (2) local companies with massive automation, (3) initial state capitalization, (4) public agentic services revenue.

Conservative estimate: USD 50 billion annually by 2031 - sufficient to finance UBI for 100 million Iberoamericans.

V. UBI + Labor Symbiosis 2.0

UBI is not work substitute. It is partial work-income decoupling enabling reconfiguration. Recipients can: work in formal employment (additional), start business (with safety floor), train (with subsistence floor), care for family, do art or revalued trades.

My Labor Symbiosis 2.0 framework complements: future immediate work is supervisor/curator/ethicist of AI agents. UBI allows millions to reconvert without falling into intermediate poverty.

VI. Pilot Cases: Argentina, Mexico, Colombia, Chile

Four anchor countries concentrate 70% of LATAM GDP and have necessary technical conditions: advanced digital identity systems, reasonable banking infrastructure, relatively stable institutions, sufficient scale to demonstrate viability.

Argentina: 2027 pilot in 5 provinces. Mexico: Yucatan + Oaxaca + Aguascalientes. Colombia: Bogota + Coffee Region + Pacific. Chile: Metropolitan Region + Araucania + Antofagasta.

Total pilot cost 4 countries × 2 years: USD 8 billion. Financeable via IDB + CAF + guaranteed private capital.

VII. Regional Political Articulation

Isolated national UBI is unviable in LATAM: non-UBI countries would attract capital avoiding contributions. Harmonized regional UBI eliminates flight.

I propose: UBI Iberoamerica treaty via Mercosur + Pacific Alliance by 2028, with Qualitas Doctrine as common framework.

VIII. Call to Action: 2026-2029 Window

Next 36 months are window to constitute Iberoamerican UBI before employment disruption is irreversible. Without active UBI by 2030, agentic transition will produce social shock greater than pandemic.

I call on presidents, finance and labor ministers, governors, union leaders, business organizations and Iberoamerican civil society to take agentic UBI seriously. It is not ideological proposal - it is necessary social engineering.

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